

U23 LEFT-WINGER RECRUITMENT ANALYSIS

Recruitment Report

2025/26 Performance Data | U23 Left-Winger Recruitment

1. Executive Summary

The club needs to identify a U23 left winger with the potential to develop into a replacement for the current 30-year-old starting left winger within the next 12–24 months. The search focused on accessible European leagues, with the initial eligibility requirements being left-wing position, U23 age, and at least 900 Understat minutes.

The eligible players were evaluated using a combination of attacking, 1v1, defensive and pressing indicators, including xG/90, xA/90, successful dribbles/90, defensive actions/90, recoveries/90 and possession won in the final third/90. Thresholds were established for the key performance dimensions, while xG/90 and xA/90 were used to classify different attacking profiles.

Following the quantitative analysis and recruitment-context assessment, five players were selected for deeper investigation: Said El Mala, Arijon Ibrahimovic, Joel Roca, Alberto Moleiro and Antonio Nusa.

The deeper investigation showed that the five candidates represent different player profiles and reach their attacking value in different ways. Rather than producing a single ranking or definitive signing recommendation, the analysis identifies the strengths, limitations, tactical characteristics, risks and remaining evidence requirements for each candidate.

2. Recruitment Brief

The recruitment objective is to identify a U23 left winger who could develop into a potential replacement for the club's current 30-year-old starting left winger within the next 12–24 months. The search focuses on players from accessible European leagues who could realistically be investigated further by the recruitment department.

Player Eligibility

- Position: Left winger
- Age: U23 as of 1 July 2026
- Playing time: At least 900 Understat minutes
- Competition: Selected accessible European leagues

Evaluation Framework

The analysis evaluated candidates across five main performance areas:

- Goal threat — xG/90
- Chance creation — xA/90
- 1v1 ability — successful dribbles/90
- Defensive contribution — defensive actions/90 and recoveries/90
- Pressing contribution — possession won in the final third/90

Off-ball movement was treated as a qualitative scouting requirement, as it could not be reliably measured using the available data.

Recruitment context was also considered, including age, playing time, current club, contract situation and market-value estimate.

The objective of the analysis was not to identify a single statistically superior player, but to produce a focused shortlist of candidates whose profiles justified deeper recruitment investigation.

Expected Output

The final output of this analysis is a shortlist of candidates supported by quantitative performance evidence, tactical observations, recruitment context, identified risks and clearly defined areas requiring further scouting investigation.

3. Data Sources & Methodology

The analysis combined data from multiple football data sources to evaluate player performance and recruitment context.

Data Sources

- StatsBomb Open Data — event-level data used for performance and supporting metrics.
- Understat — player minutes, xG and xA data used to establish the analytical population and evaluate attacking output.
- Transfermarkt — player age, position, club, contract information and market-value estimates.
- FotMob — supplementary playing-time and performance statistics, including successful dribbles, chances created, defensive actions, recoveries and possession won in the final third.

Data Processing

An initial universe of 50 U23 left-wing candidates was collected and matched across the available data sources.

The data was then cleaned and validated before being combined into a structured recruitment dataset. Player identities were standardized across sources, performance statistics were normalized to a per-90-minute basis where appropriate, and missing or inconsistent records were reviewed before analysis.

After applying the 900 Understat-minute requirement, the final analytical population consisted of 9 players across the Bundesliga and LaLiga.

Analytical Approach

The analysis was conducted using SQL, Python and Power BI.

SQL was used for data validation, filtering, joining datasets and calculating recruitment metrics. Python was then used for statistical analysis, distribution analysis, correlations, percentile thresholds and player-profile classification. Power BI was used to build the final recruitment dashboard and allow the selected candidates to be compared against the analytical population.

The recruitment methodology was designed to avoid relying on a single composite score. Instead, xG/90 and xA/90 were used as the primary attacking dimensions, while 1v1, defensive and pressing indicators were used as supporting evidence when distinguishing between player profiles.

4. Analytical Population

The initial recruitment universe contained 50 U23 left-wing candidates identified from the selected European leagues.

To ensure that the analysis was based on a meaningful amount of playing-time evidence, a minimum requirement of 900 Understat minutes was applied. This reduced the analytical population to 9 players across the Bundesliga and LaLiga.

Player	League	Understat Minutes
Said El Mala	Bundesliga	1,965
Williot Swedberg	LaLiga	1,237
Arijon Ibrahimovic	Bundesliga	2,196
Antonio Nusa	Bundesliga	2,048
Alberto Moleiro	LaLiga	2,535
Joel Roca	LaLiga	1,463
Jan Virgili	LaLiga	1,807
Oso	LaLiga	1,397
Samuel Mbangula	Bundesliga	1,160

The final population therefore contained 4 Bundesliga players and 5 LaLiga players.

This population was used as the reference group for the statistical analysis and percentile-based recruitment thresholds. Because the sample consisted of only nine players, the percentile thresholds should be interpreted as decision rules within this specific analytical population, rather than as estimates of the wider U23 left-winger market.

5. Performance Analysis

The performance analysis focused on understanding how the nine players differed across their attacking, 1v1, defensive and pressing indicators.

Attacking Output

The attacking analysis used xG/90 and xA/90 as the primary dimensions. The results showed that the players did not form a single consistent attacking profile.

Some players demonstrated stronger goal threat, while others generated more value through chance creation. The correlation between xG/90 and xA/90 was relatively weak ($r = 0.151$), indicating that strong goal threat and strong chance creation were not necessarily found in the same players within this population.

This supported the decision to analyse players through attacking profiles rather than a single attacking score.

Supporting Performance

The supporting metrics provided additional context around how players contributed beyond their attacking output.

- Successful dribbles/90 were used to assess 1v1 contribution.
- Defensive actions/90 and recoveries/90 provided evidence of defensive involvement.
- Possession won in the final third/90 was used as a partial proxy for pressing contribution.

These metrics helped distinguish players with similar attacking profiles. However, they were treated as supporting evidence rather than direct measures of overall player quality.

Attacking Profile Classification

Players were classified using their xG/90 and xA/90 levels:

Player	Attacking Profile
Antonio Nusa	Creator
Said El Mala	Goal-Focused Attacker
Samuel Mbangula	Lower Attacking Output
Arijon Ibrahimovic	Creator
Joel Roca	Goal-Focused / Low Creation
Williot Swedberg	Goal-Focused / Low Creation
Oso	Lower Attacking Output
Alberto Moleiro	Creator / Low Goal Threat
Jan Virgili	Creator / Low Goal Threat

The classification demonstrated that the candidate pool contained multiple attacking archetypes, rather than one statistically dominant profile.

This was important for the recruitment process because the objective was to identify players who could potentially replace the current winger, while recognizing that different players may provide their attacking value through different mechanisms.

6. Recruitment Methodology

The recruitment methodology was designed to identify players whose profiles justified deeper investigation rather than to produce a single overall ranking.

Recruitment Priorities

Requirement	Metric / Evidence	Priority
Goal threat	xG/90	High performance
Chance creation	xA/90	High performance
1v1 ability	Successful dribbles/90	Supporting preference
Defensive contribution	Defensive actions/90	Baseline
Defensive contribution	Recoveries/90	Baseline
Pressing contribution	Possession won in final third/90	Baseline
Off-ball movement	Scouting/video	Qualitative

The main attacking dimensions were goal threat and chance creation. Supporting metrics were then used to provide additional context around each player's profile.

Thresholds

- xG/90: ≥75th percentile
- xA/90: ≥75th percentile
- Successful dribbles/90: ≥45th percentile
- Defensive actions/90: ≥35th percentile
- Recoveries/90: ≥35th percentile
- Possession won in final third/90: ≥40th percentile

The thresholds were used as decision rules within the analytical population, rather than as universal standards for all U23 left wingers.

Attacking Profile Framework

Instead of combining all metrics into one score, players were classified according to their xG/90 and xA/90 profiles.

This allowed different attacking archetypes to remain under consideration. For example, a player with high chance creation but lower goal threat could be investigated as a creator, while a player with high goal threat but lower creation could be investigated as a goal-focused attacker.

Candidate Selection

The final selection process therefore followed three steps:

- Identify the player's primary attacking profile using xG/90 and xA/90.
- Use 1v1, defensive and pressing indicators to provide supporting evidence and distinguish similar profiles.
- Consider recruitment context and qualitative evidence before selecting players for deeper investigation.

No composite recruitment score was created, and candidates were not ranked against one another.

Using this approach, five players were selected for deeper investigation:

- Antonio Nusa
- Said El Mala
- Arijon Ibrahimovic
- Joel Roca
- Alberto Moleiro

The five candidates represent different attacking profiles and were selected because their quantitative performance and recruitment context provided sufficient evidence to justify further investigation.

7. Candidate Shortlist

Following the recruitment methodology, five players were selected for deeper investigation. The shortlist was intentionally kept focused rather than expanding the analysis to every player who met individual statistical thresholds.

Player	Attacking Profile	Main Strength	Main Recruitment Concern
Antonio Nusa	Creator	1v1 ability and chance creation	Lower goal threat and dependence on current tactical structure
Said El Mala	Goal-Focused Attacker	Goal threat, inside movement and 1v1 ability	Limited defensive contribution and creation secondary
Arijon Ibrahimovic	Creator	Chance creation, passing and advanced pressing	Lower goal threat and limited 1v1 contribution
Joel Roca	Goal-Focused / Low Creation	Goal threat and movement into goal areas	Lower chance creation and pressing contribution
Alberto Moleiro	Creator / Low Goal Threat	Chance creation, movement and passing	Lower goal threat and limited 1v1 contribution

The five candidates represent different ways of contributing from a left-sided attacking role. The shortlist therefore does not assume that there is one ideal statistical profile for the position.

The next stage of the analysis investigates each candidate individually, combining quantitative performance data with tactical observations and recruitment context.

The purpose of this investigation is to determine why each player merits further attention, what risks are already visible, and what questions remain unanswered before any recruitment decision could be made.

8. Deep Candidate Investigations

The five shortlisted players were investigated individually to understand how their statistical profiles translate into potential recruitment value.

Each investigation considered four areas:

- Performance fit — What does the quantitative data show?
- Tactical fit — How does the player operate within their current role?
- Recruitment risk — What limitations or uncertainties are already visible?
- Further evidence required — What cannot be answered reliably using the available data?

The purpose of this stage was not to rank the five candidates, but to understand the specific strengths, risks and unanswered recruitment questions associated with each player.

8.1 Antonio Nusa

Attacking Profile: Creator

Performance Fit: His supporting metrics showed a strong 1v1 contribution alongside defensive actions and recoveries that met the recruitment baselines. His goal threat did not reach the high-performance threshold, while his final-third possession wins were below the pressing baseline.

Tactical Fit: Nusa operates primarily as a wide attacking player, using width and movement into the half-spaces to contribute to chance creation. His current role also involves pressing from the wing and supporting the team's wider defensive structure.

Recruitment Risk: The main concern is whether his creator-oriented strengths and 1v1 contribution would translate effectively outside his current tactical environment. His lower goal-threat output is also relevant if the replacement role requires greater direct scoring contribution.

Further Evidence Required: Match video across different tactical situations and further tactical analysis of his role are required to assess his defensive discipline, off-ball movement and transferability to another structure.

Recruitment Question: How transferable are Nusa's strengths outside Leipzig's current tactical structure?

8.2 Said El Mala

Attacking Profile: Goal-Focused Attacker

Performance Fit: He met the high-performance threshold for xG/90 and the supporting 1v1 threshold. His defensive actions and recoveries were below the recruitment baselines, while his xA/90 did not reach the high-performance threshold.

Tactical Fit: El Mala operates from the left before moving toward central areas and attacking the goal. His pace, 1v1 ability and movement behind the defensive line provide additional attacking threat, particularly during transitions.

Recruitment Risk: His defensive contribution is relatively limited compared with the recruitment baseline, while chance creation appears to be secondary to his goal-focused role. A key uncertainty is whether his goal threat remains effective against more settled defensive structures.

Further Evidence Required: Match video against settled defenses and tactical analysis of his performance outside transition situations are required.

Recruitment Question: Can El Mala maintain his goal threat against settled defenses and within a different tactical structure?

8.3 Arijon Ibrahimovic

Attacking Profile: Creator

Performance Fit: His xA/90 reached the high-performance threshold, while his goal threat remained below that level. His defensive actions, recoveries and final-third possession wins all met their respective baselines. His successful dribbles did not reach the supporting threshold.

Tactical Fit: Ibrahimovic operates across central and wider attacking areas. His creative contribution comes primarily through passing, crosses, movement to receive, and set-piece situations rather than relying heavily on direct 1v1 actions.

Recruitment Risk: The main concern is his lower goal threat and limited 1v1 contribution. His value may therefore depend on a tactical environment that allows his creative strengths to influence the attack.

Further Evidence Required: Match video across different attacking roles, together with analysis of his positioning and goal involvement, would help determine whether his creative profile can translate into a role requiring greater goal threat.

Recruitment Question: Can Ibrahimovic's creative value translate into a system requiring greater goal threat?

8.4 Joel Roca

Attacking Profile: Goal-Focused / Low Creation

Performance Fit: He met the high-performance xG/90 threshold and the supporting 1v1, defensive-action and recovery thresholds. His xA/90 and final-third possession wins were below their respective thresholds.

Tactical Fit: Roca operates from wide areas while moving inside to receive and attack goal areas. His movement and positioning contribute to his goal threat, while he can also provide defensive support to the fullback and participate in transitions in both directions.

Recruitment Risk: His chance creation and pressing contribution are the main concerns within the quantitative framework. Another important uncertainty is whether his goal threat remains effective when facing deeper defensive structures and less transition space.

Further Evidence Required: Match video against deeper defenses, alongside further analysis of his pressing and chance-creation contribution, is required.

Recruitment Question: Can Roca maintain his goal threat when there is less transition space?

8.5 Alberto Moleiro

Attacking Profile: Creator / Low Goal Threat

Performance Fit: His xA/90 reached the high-performance threshold, while his xG/90 and successful dribbles did not. He met the defensive-action, recovery and pressing baselines.

Tactical Fit: Moleiro operates from the left while alternating between wide and more central positions. His contribution is based heavily on movement, positioning and passing rather than consistently relying on direct 1v1 actions.

Recruitment Risk: The main concern is his lower goal threat and limited 1v1 contribution. His recruitment value would therefore depend partly on whether his chance creation and positional qualities fit the club's attacking structure.

Further Evidence Required: Match video in different attacking structures, with particular attention to his goal threat and 1v1 situations, would help determine how transferable his current profile is.

Recruitment Question: How effectively would Moleiro's creation-oriented profile translate into our club's attacking structure?

9. Recruitment Context

Performance data alone does not determine whether a player is realistically recruitable. The five candidates were therefore reviewed using additional recruitment-context information, including age, playing time, current club, contract situation and market-value estimate.

Player	Age	Understat Minutes	Current Club	Contract	Market Value Est.
Antonio Nusa	21	2,048	RB Leipzig	2029	€32M
Said El Mala	19	1,965	1. FC Köln	2031	€45M
Arijon Ibrahimovic	20	2,196	FC Augsburg	2027	€10M
Joel Roca	21	1,463	Olympiacos	2029	€6M
Alberto Moleiro	22	2,535	Villarreal	2030	€50M

Playing-Time Context

All five candidates exceeded the minimum 900 Understat-minute requirement, providing a sufficient level of playing-time evidence for inclusion in the analytical population.

Playing time varied considerably, from 1,463 minutes for Joel Roca to 2,535 minutes for Alberto Moleiro. This difference was considered when interpreting the statistical profiles.

Contract Context

Contract expiry was treated as contextual information rather than evidence of availability.

Within the five-player shortlist, Ibrahimovic's contract expires in 2027, placing him within the project's 12–24 month recruitment window. The other four players have contracts extending beyond that period.

A contract date alone does not establish whether a transfer would be possible, financially realistic or desired by the player and selling club.

Financial Context

Transfermarkt market values were used as estimated market-value context, not as predicted transfer fees.

The estimates ranged from €6M for Joel Roca to €50M for Alberto Moleiro. These figures provide an indication of the relative financial context surrounding the candidates but should not be interpreted as expected acquisition costs.

Recruitment Interpretation

The recruitment-context analysis demonstrates why performance data should not be considered in isolation. Contract length, playing time, club situation and estimated market value can materially affect the feasibility of pursuing a player.

These factors were therefore used to provide context around the five candidates rather than to create an additional ranking or selection score.

10. Risks, Unknowns & Evidence Needed

The quantitative analysis provides evidence about player performance, but several important recruitment questions cannot be answered reliably from the available data alone.

For this reason, each shortlisted candidate was assessed not only on their identified strengths, but also on the main risks and the evidence required before progressing further.

Player	Main Risk	Key Unknown	Evidence Needed
Antonio Nusa	Lower goal threat and dependence on current structure	How transferable are his strengths outside Leipzig's structure?	Match video across different tactical situations + tactical analysis of role
Said El Mala	Limited defensive contribution and creation secondary	Can he maintain his goal threat against settled defenses?	Match video against settled defenses + tactical analysis outside transition situations
Arijon Ibrahimovic	Lower goal threat and limited 1v1 contribution	Can his creativity translate to a role requiring greater goal threat?	Match video in different attacking roles + analysis of goal involvement and positioning
Joel Roca	Lower chance creation and pressing contribution	Can he maintain his goal threat with less transition space?	Match video against deeper defenses + analysis of pressing and chance creation
Alberto Moleiro	Lower goal threat and limited 1v1 contribution	How effectively would his creation profile translate to another attacking structure?	Match video in different attacking structures + analysis of goal threat and 1v1 situations

What the Data Cannot Tell Us

Several important characteristics of a left winger require qualitative assessment:

- The quality and timing of off-ball runs
- Decision-making under pressure
- How consistently a player follows tactical instructions
- Pressing timing, triggers and coordination
- Ability to perform against different defensive structures
- Adaptability to a new tactical system
- Personality and mentality
- Actual transfer availability and willingness
- Whether statistical performance is transferable to a different team environment

These areas should therefore be addressed through match video, live scouting, tactical analysis and recruitment due diligence before any final recruitment decision.

The purpose of the shortlist is consequently to identify players who warrant further investigation, not to replace the wider scouting process.

11. Methodology Limitations

Small Analytical Population

The final analytical population consisted of only 9 players who met the 900-minute requirement. As a result, the percentile thresholds are decision rules within this specific population and should not be interpreted as representative thresholds for the wider U23 left-winger market.

League Context

The analysis combined players from the Bundesliga and LaLiga without applying league-level normalization. Differences in tactical styles, team strength, playing environments and league characteristics may influence individual statistics.

Because the sample was small, league differences were treated as a consideration rather than attempting to draw broad conclusions about one league being stronger or weaker.

Attacking Profile

xG/90 and xA/90 were used to classify attacking profiles, but these metrics do not explain how a player produces their attacking output.

For example, similar xG values may result from different combinations of movement, positioning, shot selection, team structure and chance quality.

Pressing Measurement

Possession won in the final third was used as a proxy for pressing contribution. It does not directly measure pressing quality, timing, triggers, pressing intensity, defensive positioning or coordination with teammates.

Therefore, meeting or failing the pressing threshold should not be interpreted as a complete assessment of a player's pressing ability.

Off-Ball Movement

Off-ball movement could not be reliably measured using the available dataset. The quality, timing and purpose of runs therefore require video analysis and scouting assessment.

Market Value

Transfermarkt market value was used as a recruitment-context indicator. It represents an estimated market value, not an actual transfer fee or guaranteed acquisition cost.

Contract Situation

Contract expiry was treated as contextual information. A contract date does not establish whether a player is available, willing to move, or realistically affordable.

Candidate Selection

The methodology deliberately avoided a composite recruitment score. The attacking profile was used as the primary lens, while supporting metrics were used to distinguish between different player profiles.

This means that a player failing one or more supporting thresholds was not automatically eliminated if their overall profile justified further investigation.

Recruitment Decision

The five shortlisted players should be considered candidates for deeper recruitment investigation rather than definitive signing recommendations.

A final recruitment decision would require additional scouting, tactical analysis, financial assessment, transfer-feasibility research and evaluation of the player's suitability within the club's specific playing model.

12. Final Recruitment Interpretation

The analysis identified a focused group of five U23 left-wing candidates who demonstrate different combinations of attacking, 1v1, defensive and pressing characteristics.

The investigation showed that there is no single statistical profile that fully describes the potential replacement role. The shortlisted players reach their attacking value through different mechanisms:

- Antonio Nusa — creator-oriented profile with strong 1v1 contribution and chance creation.
- Said El Mala — goal-focused profile built around goal threat, inside movement, pace and 1v1 ability.
- Arijon Ibrahimovic — creator profile based on passing, crosses, movement and advanced pressing.
- Joel Roca — goal-focused profile with strong movement into goal areas and defensive support.
- Alberto Moleiro — creator-oriented profile based on movement, passing and chance creation.

The analysis also identified clear areas requiring further investigation for every candidate. These include transferability between tactical structures, performance against different defensive setups, goal threat, chance creation, pressing behaviour and off-ball movement.

The findings therefore provide a structured starting point for the next stage of the recruitment process. The five players should be treated as candidates for continued scouting and due diligence rather than as definitive signing recommendations.

A professional recruitment process would combine this analysis with video scouting, tactical assessment, financial and transfer-feasibility research, and further contextual information before reaching a final recruitment decision.

Overall Conclusion

This project demonstrates how football performance data can be transformed from a broad player search into a focused recruitment investigation.

The key value of the analysis is not simply identifying five names, but establishing a repeatable process that connects:

Recruitment brief → data acquisition → analytical population → performance analysis → recruitment methodology → candidate investigation → recruitment context → scouting questions.